Newspaper article mounted on fibreboard about Maria Ierullo by Jane Mosgrove about 2003			Maria was thrilled to be part of the Presenza exhibit. At the time she was in failing health. She could still outpace me when using her walker and could still speak passionately about the urban renewal evictions of the Preston Street area in the mid 1960s.

A stitch of love

Little Italy's angel

By Jane Mosgrove
The News

For anyone seeking an ample dose of inspiration, look no further than a conversation with Mary Ierullo.

Fair warning, several hours should be set aside in order to scratch the surface of this woman's life story.

Following in her mother's footsteps, Ms. Ierullo embarked on many firsts as she sought to open doors for generations after hers.

She was the first female real estate broker in Canada, the capital's first woman court interpreter and she was the first to set-up a prenatal clinic at the Civic Hospital in the 1950s.

Earlier this year, she received recognition by the Italian Women of the Village for her lifetime service to residents of the Preston St. area.

Ms. Ierullo's story is also among those highlighted in a Museum of Civilization's exhibit entitled Presenza — a New Look at Italian-Canadian Heritage. The exhibit, on display until Sept., 2004, includes more than 300 artifacts on loan from 140 individuals covering the period between 1880 and 1970, when more than 650,000 Italians came to Canada.

Despite a lengthy resumé, this diminutive woman is rather bashful about what she has done.

"I think I must give something back for all I've been given," said 83-year-old, over lunch at St. Patrick's Home. "Besides I could not have done what I did without God's help and everyone else too."

Born April 1, 1920 in Calabria Italy, Ms. Ierullo landed in Halifax Nov.27, 1928 with her mother, Angela, an uncle and her grandmother. The family arrived in Ottawa in 1930 and settled in the Preston St. area, known then as the Village.

Tragically widowed shortly after her husband's arrival in Ottawa, Angela started an embroidery business to sustain the family.

In addition to attending St. Anthony's School, Ms. Ierullo helped her mother with the embroidery business by tracing the patterns.

"We shared the work. It was important to both of us," she said.

The young Ms. Ierullo also spent time after supper with her uncle as he taught her to speak and write in English.

After graduating from commerce school in 1936, she worked as a typing instructor for two years before passing her stenography test, and landing a secretarial position in the federal government.

In 1946, Ms. Ierullo's mother died and the 26-year-old felt her calling might be religious. She entered the convent in Ottawa, eating meals and sleeping there while still maintaining employment with the government.

A sister in the convent spoke with Ms. Ierullo, saying God may have other plans for her.

That proved to be a prophetic statement since on Aug.12, 1950 Ms. Ierullo married Jimmy (Vincenzo) Ierullo. The couple had a daughter, named Angela after her grandmother. Angela is currently a resident of the Britannia area.

After Jimmy suffered several back injuries while working in construction, Ms. Ierullo's strong lineage of pioneering women took hold and she re-entered the workforce.

A mother of three children, Peter and Anthony as well as Angela, she became the first female real estate broker in Canada. While she started out selling homes with an established company in the early 1950s, Ms. Ierullo started out on her own within two years.

"Some people are still stopping to ask me if I'm still selling or if I can help them," she said, smiling.

Starting her own real estate company was itself a feat, but, Ms. Ierullo did not stop there. She went on to hire 16 agents, 14 of whom were women of different backgrounds and cultures. This provided work experience to recent immigrants and also offered those seeking a home the chance to do so in the comfort of their own language.

"She helped people that would not have been helped by anyone else," said daughter Angela.

There were many occasions when Ms. Ierullo forewent her fees to ensure immigrants had somewhere to live. "It was much more important for me to help people have a home than to take their money," she said.

Her own home was the site of Sunday evening gatherings where she helped new home buyers, many of whom did not speak or write English well, to fill out mortgage-related paperwork.

"I think I must give something back for all I've been given."
— Mary Ierullo

Ms. Ierullo supplemented the family income as an Italian-English translator for the Workers' Compensation Board for 35 years and in local courtrooms for more than 50 years, despite the fact it was a male dominated profession, where the men made about four times more money for the same work.

Ms. Ierullo also translated for workers within the unions in the 1950s, seeking to ensure they were fairly represented.

"I had the strength of character to stand firm to the faith I have and to not be pushed around. God created us all equal," she said.

Frustrated by the fact she knew many of her fellow Italians had skills to work in their community but did not speak English, Ms. Ierullo dug in.

"You don't have to break the language barrier because everyone can be understood," she said. Ms. Ierullo took it upon herself to take prospective workers to businesses suitable for them and convince owners to let the job seeker show them what they could do rather than tell them.

It's difficult to fathom, with this impressive list of accomplishments, that Ms. Ierullo found time for anything else, but indeed she did.

In the 1960s, she fought the city's attempts to expropriate homes in the Preston St area and helped establish formal zoning policies to safeguard land ownership.

"You name it she did all of it," Angela said, proudly.

Mary Ierullo is esteemed for her contributions to the city, and especially to the Preston St. area, known as the Village. Pictured here with her daughter, Angela, Ms. Ierullo made many inroads for females in the city and beyond, becoming the first woman real estate broker in Canada and the first female court translator.

Photo by Jane Mosgrove